KEY TOPIC 1 • REVISION & PRACTICE COMPANION

Medicine in Medieval Britain, c1250–c1500

Ideas on Causes, Prevention, Treatment, Medical Care & The Black Death



Primary Visual Evidence: *Medieval Plague Sufferers in Bed with Buboes* • Toggenburg Bible MS (1411) **CONTEMPORARY PRINT ARCHIVE**

PUPIL NAME: _____ **TARGET:** _____ **CLASS:** _____

KEY TOPIC 1 SPECIFICATION FRAMEWORK (1HI0/11)	LESSON DONE	QUIZ [10]
Key Topic 1.1: Supernatural & Religious Explanations of Disease *Why did the Catholic Church, scriptoria, and divine retribution dominate medieval understanding of illness?*	☐	☐
Key Topic 1.2: Rational Explanations: Hippocrates, Galen & The Four Humours *Why did the Theory of Opposites, uroscopy wheels, and miasma remain unchallenged for centuries?*	☐	☐
Key Topic 1.3: Approaches to Prevention & Treatment: Rituals, Bleeding & Purging *How did medieval physicians balance fleam bloodletting, treacle theriac, and the Regimen Sanitatis?*	☐	☐
Key Topic 1.4: Medical Care Providers & Monastic Hospitals: 'Care Not Cure' *Who cared for the sick, and why did monastic hospitals prioritize spiritual comfort over medical cure?*	☐	☐
Key Topic 1.5: Case Study: Dealing with the Black Death (1348–1349) *Why was medieval society entirely powerless against the arrival of Yersinia pestis at Melcombe Regis?*	☐	☐

c. 1250 • The Church & The Monopoly on Medical Learning

Key Topic 1.1

The Catholic Church controls all English universities (Oxford, Cambridge) and hospital foundations. Monks hand-copy medical manuscripts in scriptoria, preserving Galen's anatomical writings because his teleological view—that the body had a single divine Creator—aligned with Christian dogma.

1277 • The Imprisonment of Roger Bacon

Key Topic 1.1

Franciscan friar and Oxford scholar Roger Bacon is imprisoned by church leaders for heresy after writing that physicians should conduct original scientific experiments rather than blindly copying Galen. This imprisonment effectively halts independent anatomical inquiry for over two centuries.

c. 1300 • The Diagnostic Tools: Matula Flasks & The Zodiac Man

Key Topic 1.2

Physicians practice uroscopy using glass matula flasks, comparing urine colour, density, and smell against 20-shade charts to diagnose humoral imbalance. They carry Vademecum pocketbooks containing the Zodiac Man to determine safe planetary alignments for phlebotomy (bloodletting).

c. 1320 • The Medical Hierarchy: Physicians, Barber-Surgeons & Apothecaries

Key Topic 1.4

A rigid division of medical labour establishes in England. Fewer than 100 elite university-trained physicians diagnose wealthy nobility. Town apothecaries mix theriac and herbal compounds, while lower-status barber-surgeons perform tooth-pulling, wound-cautery, and bloodletting.

 Roger Bacon spent years in a prison cell for suggesting doctors should actually test things. Remember that when your teacher asks you to write an extra paragraph!

c. 1350 • Monastic Hospitals: The Era of 'Care Not Cure'

Key Topic 1.4

Over 1,200 hospitals run by monks and nuns operate in England (e.g. St Bartholomew's, 1123). Patients receive clean bedding, warmth, food, and continuous prayer facing a chapel altar. Zero surgery or medical cure is attempted; lepers and plague victims are strictly barred.

1345 • The Great Planetary Conjunction in Aquarius

Key Topic 1.5

In March 1345, Mars, Jupiter, and Saturn align in Aquarius. University of Paris physicians state this celestial conjunction drew up poisonous vapours from the earth, corrupting the air with deadly miasma, preparing Europe for the Black Death.

1348 • The Black Death Reaches Melcombe Regis, Dorset

Key Topic 1.5

In June 1348, the pestilence arrives on trade ships carrying black rats and fleas. The dual epidemic—bubonic plague (flea bites, agonizing buboes) and pneumonic plague (airborne coughing droplets)—kills 30–50% of England's population within 18 months.

1349 • King Edward III's Cleanliness Order & East Smithfield Mass Pits

Key Topic 1.5

Alarmed by rotting waste and stench, Edward III orders London streets cleared of dung to remove miasma. Churchyards overflow; emergency mass burial trenches are dug outside city walls at East Smithfield to bury hundreds of corpses daily.

King Edward III ordered Londoners to clean human filth off the streets in 1349. Outstanding for civic smell, totally useless against Yersinia pestis fleas.

Why did the Catholic Church dominate medieval explanations of disease?

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • CORE CAUSAL NARRATIVE

Take precise, structured notes alongside each milestone as your teacher narrates the history

1 **c1250**

Scriptoria & Church Monopoly on Learning

- Hand-copying Latin manuscripts by candle-light
- Training university priests in Church doctrine
- Punishing medical heretics like Roger Bacon

FOCUS CLUE
How did church scriptoria prevent new medical ideas from spreading?

2 **c1280**

Biblical Leprosy & Divine Retribution

- Sending sickness to punish human sin
- Exiling lepers to isolated Lazar houses
- Ringing warning bells in dirt lanes

FOCUS CLUE
Why was leprosy viewed as visible proof of divine judgment?

3 **1345**

Christian Astrology & Planetary Conjunction

- Consulting parchment zodiac almanac wheels
- Aligning Mars, Jupiter, and Saturn in Aquarius
- Blaming corrupted night air for fever

FOCUS CLUE
How did the Church reconcile astrology with Christian doctrine?

4 **c1350**

Purgatory, Saints & Holy Relics

- Lighting beeswax candles before parish shrines
- Kissing holy bone relics of saints
- Selling paper indulgences to wealthy barons

FOCUS CLUE
Why did sick people turn to pilgrimage shrines rather than doctors?

5 **c1400**

Censorship & The Ban on Dissection

- Treating Galen's pagan texts as sacred truth
- Banning human dissections in English towns
- Threatening curious scholars with church excommunication

FOCUS CLUE
Why did church enforcement of Galen prevent medical progress?

If you develop a fever in 1300, church logic dictates you definitely committed a sin last Tuesday. Time to buy a pilgrimage badge!

Question 4: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins]

Explain why the Catholic Church had such a major influence on ideas about the causes of disease in the period c1250–c1500. [12 marks]

Stimulus: Monastic scriptoria and book-copying | The imprisonment of Roger Bacon (1277) *(You must also use information of your own)*

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:

One main reason was that... • For example, ... • This was important because... • Another key factor was... • In particular, ... • Overall, the most decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

divine retribution • biblical leprosy • Lazar houses • teleology • heresy • Roger Bacon (1277) • monastic scriptoria • 1345 planetary conjunction • astrological almanacs

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on facing page)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 1.1). In the drawing box, sketch a monk copying Galen's medical book in a scriptorium. Add two speech bubbles explaining why the Church banned new medical experiments and imprisoned Roger Bacon in 1277. **[ ] Done**

Continue your response to Question 4 below:

Final analytical evaluation & concluding historical verdict:

• QUESTION 3: EXPLAIN ONE SIMILARITY [4 MARKS] [4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which ideas about the cause of disease in the Medieval period (c1250–c1500) were similar to ideas in the Renaissance period (c1500–c1700). [4 marks]

Why did the Theory of the Four Humours dominate rational medicine for centuries?

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • CORE CAUSAL NARRATIVE

Take precise, structured notes alongside each milestone as your teacher narrates the history

1 c460 BC

Hippocrates & Natural Observation

- Rejecting anger of gods at the bedside
- Writing case charts on fever symptoms
- Swearing ethical oath to protect patients

FOCUS CLUE
How did Hippocrates separate medicine from superstition?

2 c1250

The Four Bodily Humours

- Balancing blood, phlegm, and two biles
- Linking fluids to four earthly elements
- Associating cold damp seasons with winter coughs

FOCUS CLUE
Why did humoral theory seem logical to medieval people?

3 c1280

Galen's Theory of Opposites

- Cooling burning summer fever with cold cucumber
- Treating excess phlegm with dry hot pepper
- Dissecting Barbary apes to map organs

FOCUS CLUE
How did the Theory of Opposites provide practical treatment rules?

4 c1300

The Matula & Diagnostic Uroscopy

- Holding glass flasks up to window sunlight
- Comparing urine colours against twenty-shade wheels
- Sniffing and tasting samples for sweetness

FOCUS CLUE
Why did uroscopy give physicians great diagnostic authority?

5 c1350

Miasma Theory & Foul Vapours

- Fearing stench from open roadside cesspools
- Smelling rotting town refuse heaps
- Believing toxic smells unbalanced bodily fluids

FOCUS CLUE
Why did rational physicians link bad smells directly to epidemics?

Cold and wet? Have some hot dry pepper. Too much blood? Let's slice your arm open. Galen's logic was flawless, provided you survived the cure.

Question 4: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins]

EXTENDED WRITING ASSESSMENT

Explain why the Theory of the Four Humours remained the dominant rational explanation of disease throughout the period c1250–c1500. [12 marks]

Stimulus: Galen's Theory of Opposites | The diagnostic matula (uroscopy) *(You must also use information of your own)*

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:

One main reason was that... • For example, ... • This was important because... • Another key factor was... • In particular, ... • Overall, the most decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

Four Humours • blood, phlegm, yellow bile, black bile • Theory of Opposites • Galen • clinical observation • Hippocratic Oath • matula • uroscopy wheel • Zodiac Man • miasma

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on facing page)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 1.2). In the drawing box, sketch a physician holding up a glass matula flask to the sunlight. Annotate the four bodily fluids and explain how Galen's Theory of Opposites balanced them. [ ] Done

Continue your response to Question 4 below:

Final analytical evaluation & concluding historical verdict:

• QUESTION 3: EXPLAIN ONE DIFFERENCE [4 MARKS] [4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which ideas about the cause of disease in the Medieval period (c1250–c1500) were different from ideas in the Modern period (c1900–present). [4 marks]

How did medieval treatments balance religious rituals against physical remedies?

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • CORE CAUSAL NARRATIVE

Take precise, structured notes alongside each milestone as your teacher narrates the history

1 c1250

Religious Prayers, Fasting & Flagellation

- Chanting Latin prayers beside the sickbed
- Fasting on bread and well water
- Whipping bare backs to beg God for mercy

FOCUS CLUE
Why did ordinary people consider prayer more vital than medicine?

2 c1300

Humoral Phlebotomy (Bloodletting)

- Slicing vein walls with iron fleams
- Applying fat swamp leeches to temples
- Catching warm dark blood in pewter bowls

FOCUS CLUE
Why was bloodletting the most universal physical treatment?

3 c1320

Purging, Vomiting & Enemas

- Swallowing poisonous black hellebore seeds
- Pumping warm mallow tea through boar-bladder clysters
- Emptying bowels to balance bodily humours

FOCUS CLUE
How was purging believed to restore bodily equilibrium?

4 c1350

Herbal Apothecary Remedies & Theriac

- Grinding crushed mint and sage in stone mortars
- Mixing seventy ingredients into treacle theriac
- Brewing bitter willow bark teas for fever

FOCUS CLUE
Why did herbal recipes remain popular across all social classes?

5 c1400

The Regimen Sanitatis & Clean Air

- Following private Latin health rulebooks
- Burning sweet lavender sticks indoors
- Carrying fragrant posy flowers through smelly streets

FOCUS CLUE
How did wealthy barons attempt to prevent sickness before it struck?

Bleeding, purging, boiling vinegar, and swallowing crushed emeralds. If the disease didn't kill you, the apothecary's bill definitely would.

Question 4: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins]

EXTENDED WRITING ASSESSMENT

Explain why medieval treatments for disease focused heavily on restoring humoral balance and religious repentance in the period c1250–c1500. [12 marks]

Stimulus: Phlebotomy (bloodletting by fleam or leeches) | The Regimen Sanitatis *(You must also use information of your own)*

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:

One main reason was that... • For example, ... • This was important because... • Another key factor was... • In particular, ... • Overall, the most decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

phlebotomy • fleam • leeches • cupping • purging • emetics • clysters • theriac • herbal materia medica • Regimen Sanitatis • flagellants

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on facing page)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 1.3). In the drawing box, sketch a barber-surgeon using a fleam and pewter bleeding bowl, alongside a flagellant whip. Label how one treated the body and the other treated the soul. [ ] Done

Continue your response to Question 4 below:

Final analytical evaluation & concluding historical verdict:

• **QUESTION 3: EXPLAIN ONE SIMILARITY [4 MARKS]** [4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which approaches to preventing disease in the Medieval period (c1250–c1500) were similar to approaches in the Renaissance period (c1500–c1700). [4 marks]

Who provided medical care in medieval England, and why did hospitals focus on care rather than cure?

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • CORE CAUSAL NARRATIVE

Take precise, structured notes alongside each milestone as your teacher narrates the history

1 **c1250**

University-Trained Physicians

- Studying Latin texts for ten years in Oxford
- Consulting astronomical star charts for baronial clients
- Charging heavy silver fees without touching patients

FOCUS CLUE

Why were university physicians accessible only to the ultra-wealthy?

2 **c1300**

Guild Apothecaries & Spicers

- Weighing dried poppy roots on brass scales
- Selling cheap herbal pills to town weavers
- Learning trade secrets through guild apprenticeships

FOCUS CLUE

How did apothecaries provide accessible medicines to townspeople?

3 **c1320**

Barber-Surgeons & Wound Care

- Pulling rotten teeth with iron pliers
- Setting broken arm bones with wooden splints
- Cauterising bleeding flesh wounds with red-hot irons

FOCUS CLUE

Why were barber-surgeons viewed as lower-status craftsmen?

4 **c1350**

Monastic Hospitals: Care Not Cure

- Sheltering bedridden pilgrims in monastic wards
- Providing warm woollen blankets and fresh vegetable stew
- Hearing Latin mass through chapel chancel screens

FOCUS CLUE

Why did monastic hospitals deliberately avoid medical treatment?

5 **c1400**

Women Healers & Household Care

- Gathering wild chamomile in country hedgerows
- Delivering newborn babies in village cottages
- Applying warm bread poultices to swollen skin

FOCUS CLUE

Why did the vast majority of sick people rely on female family members?

Medieval hospitals: clean sheets, warm porridge, 24-hour prayer, and absolutely zero doctors. It was luxury hospitality, not clinical medicine.

Question 4: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins]

EXTENDED WRITING ASSESSMENT

Explain why hospital care in medieval England was based on the concept of 'care rather than cure' in the period c1250–c1500. [12 marks]

Stimulus: Monastic rules and religious charity | The exclusion of infectious diseases (lepers and plague victims) *(You must also use information of your own)*

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:

One main reason was that... • For example, ... • This was important because... • Another key factor was... • In particular, ... • Overall, the most decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

care not cure • monastic hospitals • St Bartholomew's (1123) • infirmarer • university physicians • apothecaries • barber-surgeons • wise women • fleam • Lazar houses

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on facing page)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 1.4). In the drawing box, sketch the interior of a monastic hospital ward showing rows of beds facing a chapel altar. Annotate why monks prioritized prayer over medical surgery. **[ ] Done**

Continue your response to Question 4 below:

Final analytical evaluation & concluding historical verdict:

• **QUESTION 3: EXPLAIN ONE DIFFERENCE [4 MARKS]** [4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which the work of hospitals in the Medieval period (c1250–c1500) was different from hospitals in the nineteenth century. [4 marks]

Why did medieval society fail to halt the devastating mortality of the Black Death?

CHRONOLOGICAL INQUIRY SPINE • CORE CAUSAL NARRATIVE

Take precise, structured notes alongside each milestone as your teacher narrates the history

1 June 1348

Arrival at Melcombe Regis

- Docking trade cogs from Gascony in Dorset
- Unloading flea-infested wool sacks onto wharves
- Spreading black rats into crowded timber cottages

FOCUS CLUE
How did trade routes unwittingly bring the plague to England?

2 Autumn 1348

Buboes & Pneumonic Terror

- Swelling agonizing egg-sized groin lumps
- Coughing bloody phlegm across family rooms
- Killing infected farm labourers within three days

FOCUS CLUE
Why was the pneumonic strain far deadlier than the bubonic form?

3 Winter 1348

Desperate Treatments & Strapped Chickens

- Lancing hard neck swellings with hot knives
- Strapping plucked live hens to dark sores
- Drinking crushed emerald stones dissolved in vinegar

FOCUS CLUE
Why were medical treatments completely useless against the plague?

4 1349

King Edward III's Cleanliness Order

- Ordering town bailiffs to clear butchered animal entrails
- Shovelling horse dung out of unpaved London streets
- Lighting smoking pitch fires at road corners

FOCUS CLUE
How did belief in miasma shape royal prevention orders?

5 1349–1350

Mass Burial Pits & Demographic Collapse

- Digging vast emergency trenches at East Smithfield
- Piling stacked corpses under thin river clay
- Losing half of England's agricultural workforce

FOCUS CLUE
Why did the Black Death trigger a long-term social and economic crisis?

In 1348, people blamed God, the planets, bad smells, and foreigners. The actual culprits—fleas on black rats—went completely unnoticed.

Question 5/6: Thematic Essay [16 marks + 4 marks SPaG • 25 mins]

EXTENDED WRITING ASSESSMENT

'The main reason why so many people died during the Black Death (1348–49) was because governments had no effective way of preventing disease.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer. [16 marks + 4 marks SPaG]

Stimulus: King Edward III's cleanliness order (1349) | Belief in miasma and supernatural causes | *(You must also use information of your own)*

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:

One main reason was that... • For example, ... • This was important because... • Another key factor was... • In particular, ... • Overall, the most decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

Black Death (1348) • Melcombe Regis • bubonic plague • pneumonic plague • Yersinia pestis • black rats • Xenopsylla cheopis fleas • buboes • King Edward III • East Smithfield mass graves • miasma

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on facing page)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 1.5). In the drawing box, sketch the arrival of a trading cog at Melcombe Regis carrying rats and fleas, alongside an emergency mass burial pit at East Smithfield. **[ ] Done**

Continue your response to Question 5/6 below:

Final analytical evaluation & concluding historical verdict:

• QUESTION 3: EXPLAIN ONE SIMILARITY [4 MARKS] [4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which responses to the Black Death (1348–49) were similar to responses to the Great Plague of London (1665). [4 marks]

KEY TOPIC 1 • MASTER KNOWLEDGE LEDGER

Specification Audit

Before sitting Edexcel Paper 1 (Section B), you must be able to deploy precise historical evidence across all five areas of Medieval Britain (c1250–c1500). Use this ledger for spaced retrieval practice.

1. SUPERNATURAL & RELIGIOUS CAUSES

- God sent disease to punish sin or test faith.
- Church controlled learning through scriptoria.
- Bacon imprisoned in 1277 for advocating experiments.
- 1345 planetary alignment of Saturn, Jupiter & Mars.

2. RATIONAL EXPLANATIONS (HUMOURS & MIASMA)

- Four Humours: blood, phlegm, yellow bile, black bile.
- Galen's Theory of Opposites balanced excess fluids.
- Matula flasks used to inspect urine against 20 shades.
- Miasma: foul air from rotting dung, waste & cesspools.

3. APPROACHES TO PREVENTION & TREATMENT

- Religious: prayer, fasting, pilgrimages, flagellation.
- Humoral: phlebotomy (vein fleams/leeches) & purging.
- Apothecaries mixed herbal compounds and theriac.
- Regimen Sanitatis: personalized lifestyle health rules.

4. HOSPITALS & THE BLACK DEATH (1348–49)

- Over 1,200 hospitals provided 'care not cure'.
- Lepers and plague victims strictly excluded.
- Arrived at Melcombe Regis via trade ships (June 1348).
- Killed 30–50% of England: 1349 London cleanliness order.

CUMULATIVE REVISION SIGN-OFF: Teacher Initial: [ ] • Date: [ ]

INTERACTIVE DIGITAL QUIZZING HUB • SCAN FOR INSTANT RETRIEVAL PRACTICE

ONLINE RECALL

KT1.1	KT1.2	KT1.3	KT1.4	KT1.5
Supernatural	Four Humours	Treatments	Hospitals	Black Death
SCAN TO QUIZ	SCAN TO QUIZ	SCAN TO QUIZ	SCAN TO QUIZ	SCAN TO QUIZ
Best Score: [/ 8]	Best Score: [/ 8]	Best Score: [/ 8]	Best Score: [/ 8]	Best Score: [/ 8]

Unlike medieval bloodletting, scanning these quiz QR codes is 100% painless and significantly more likely to boost your survival in the exam hall.